



Dried seeds

Cubelike seeds are often used in Indian cooking.



Fenugreek

These tiny black seeds are ground to make a hot sauce.



Dried seeds

Each droopy seed pod can grow up to 6 in (15 cm) in length.



Vanilla



Mustard



Dried seed pods

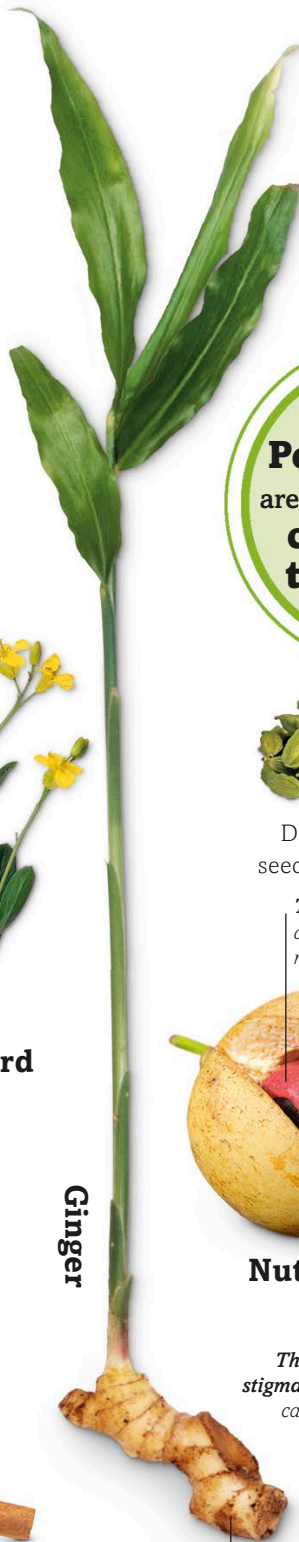


Harvesting cinnamon

The inner bark of the cinnamon tree is harvested and cut into small sticks.



Cinnamon sticks



Ginger

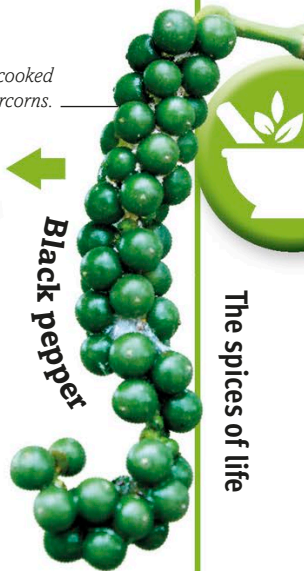
Underground stems have a hot, spicy flavor.



Dried fruits

Black pepper

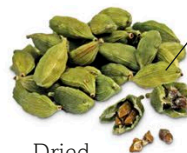
Unripe fruits are cooked and dried into peppercorns.



The spices of life

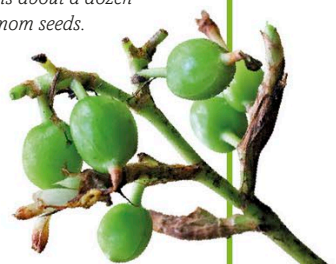
Peppercorns are the world's most commonly traded spice.

Each seed pod contains about a dozen cardamom seeds.

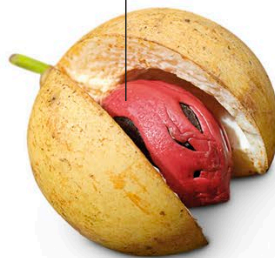


Dried seed pods

The red, outer covering around this seed is used to make another spice called mace.



Green cardamom



Nutmeg



Dried seeds

The fragrant red stigmas are harvested carefully by hand.



Saffron

Many spices come from tropical plants from East Asia. Our appetite for their flavors makes them highly valuable, and it was the demand for spices that drove European explorers and traders to sail the globe in search of precious supplies in the 15th and 16th centuries. The Italian explorer Christopher Columbus reached the Caribbean Islands while trying to find a new spice trade

route to India. Instead, he found **chile** peppers, which he brought back to Europe. Today we take for granted the exotic ingredients in our kitchen pantries. We can't imagine not having **pepper** on the table, a hot dog without **mustard**, or ice cream without **vanilla**. The most expensive spice in the world is **saffron**, which is worth more than gold by weight.